When the Bough Breaks, Dive

By Andrea Gibson

Dive

(Pg 46-48) Life doesn't rhyme.

It's bullets. . . and wind chimes.

It's lynchings. . . and birthday parties.

It's the rope that ties the noose

and the rope that hangs the backyard swing.

It's wanting tonight to speak the most honest poem

I've ever spoken in my life

not knowing if that poem should bring you closer

to living or dying.

INTRODUCTION

Every day, the suffering of so many is brought home to us through TV and social media: A thirteen-year-old girl dies of leukemia. Brown-skinned families flee for their lives, seeking asylum in countries who refuse them entry.

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Teachers use their bodies as human shields to protect students from another school shooting. A tsunami kills thousands of unsuspecting vacationers. Palestinian children kneel in the cinders of missile heads. How do we continue to take in the tragedy surrounding us without giving up all sense of hope? Andrea Gibson in her poems "When the Bough Breaks" and "Dive" gives us a unique perspective of coping when life doesn't rhyme.

When the Bough Breaks

(Pg 82-84) . . . I'm standing in an auditorium behind a
microphone

reading a poem to four hundred Latino high school kids

who live with the breath of the INS

crawling up their mothers' backbones

and I am frantically hiding my scars

'cause the last thing I want these kids to know

is that I ever thought that my life was too hard.

I've never seen a bomb drop.

I've never felt hunger.

I've also never seen lightning strike

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but I know we've all heard the thunder
and it doesn't take a genius to tell something's burning.

"Please call me by my true name,
I am the child in Uganda all skin and bone."
Do we remember the rest?
And, "Jesus Wept."
Jesus wept, but look at our eyes,
dry as the desert sand
dusting the edges of our soldier's wedding bands.

Do you know children in Palestine fly kites
to prove they're still free?
Can you imagine how that string
must feel between their fingers
as they kneel in the cinders of US-made missile heads?
You can count the dead by the colors in the sky.

The bough is breaking.
The cradle is falling.
Right now a six-year-old girl is crouched in a ditch in
Lebanon

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wishing on falling bombs.

Right now our government is recording the test scores
of Black and Latino 4th graders
to see how many prison beds will be needed in the year
20**.

Right now there's a man on the street outside my door
with outstretched hands full of heartbeats no one can hear.
He has cheeks like torn sheet music,
every tear-broken crescendo falling on deaf ears.
At his side there's a boy with eyes like an anthem
no one stands up for.

Our insanity is not that we see people who aren't there.
It's that we ignore the ones who are.
'Til we find ourselves scarred and ashamed
walking into emergency rooms at two am
flooded with a pain we cannot name or explain,
bleeding from the outside in.
Our skin is not impervious.

Cultures built on greed and destruction
do not pick and choose who they kill.

Do we really believe our need for Prozac
has nothing to do with Fallujah,
with Kabul, with the Mexican border
with the thousands of US school kids
bleeding budget cuts that will never heal
to fuel war tanks?

Thank god for denial.
Thank god we can afford the makeup
to pile upon the face of it all.
Look at the pretty world.
Look at all the smiling people,
and the sky with a missile between her teeth
and a steeple through her heart
and not a single star left to hold her

and the voices of a thousand broken nations
saying, “Wake me, wake me
when the American dream is over.”

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Andrea Gibson
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AWARD HISTORY

CO State Qualifier
Combined with Anything by Andrea Gibson

Dive (con’t)

(Pg 46-48) Last night I prayed myself to sleep,
woke this morning to find god's obituary
scrolled in tears on my sheets
then walked outside to hear my neighbor
erasing ten thousand years of hard labor
with a single note of his violin
and the sound of the traffic rang like a hymn
as the holiest leaf of autumn
fell from a plastic tree limb, beautiful
and ugly.

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Like right now I'm needing nothing more than for you to
hug me
and if you do I'm gonna scream like a caged bird.
Life doesn't rhyme.
Sometimes love is a vulgar word.

I've heard saints preaching truths
that would have burned me at the stake.
I've heard poets telling lies that made me believe in
heaven.

Sometimes i imagine Hitler at seven years old,
a paint brush in his hand at school
thinking, “What color should i paint my soul?”

Sometimes I remember myself
with track marks on my tongue
from shooting up convictions
that would have hung innocent men from trees.

Have you ever seen a mother falling to her knees
the day her son dies in a war she voted for?
Can you imagine how many gay teen-aged lives were saved

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the day Matthew Shepherd died?
Could there have been anything louder
than the noise inside his father's head
when he begged the jury, “Please don't take the lives
of the men who turned my son's skull to powder.”
And I know nothing would make my family prouder
than if I gave up everything I believe in
but nothing keeps me believing
like the sound of my mother breathing.
Life doesn't rhyme.
It's tasting your rapist's breath
on the neck of a woman who loves you more
than anyone has loved you before
then feeling holy as Mary
beneath the hands of a one-night stand
who's calling somebody else's name.

It's you never feeling more greedy
than when you're handing out dollars to the needy.

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It's my not eating meat for the last ten years
then seeing the kindest eyes I've ever seen in my life
on the face of a man with a branding iron in his hand
and a beat-down baby calf wailing at his feet.

It's choking on your beliefs.
It's your worst sin saving your life.
It's the devil's knife carving holes into your soul
so angels will have a place to make their way inside.
Life doesn't rhyme.
Life is poetry, not math.
All the world's a stage
but the stage is a meditation mat.
You tilt your head back.
You breathe.
When your heart is broken you plant seeds in the cracks
and you pray for rain.
And you teach your sons and daughters
there are sharks in the water
but the only way to survive

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is to breathe deep
and dive.

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